gress, because it was clear that the Congress would be dominated by the Mahatma and the President would be a mere dummy. They were of opinion that a Left Wing leader should accept the Presidentship only when he was in a position to have his programme adopted by the Congress. But the Mahatma took a clever step in supporting the candidature of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru and his election as President opened a new chapter in his public career. Since then, Pandit J. L. Nehru has been a consistent and unfailing supporter of the Mahatma.

In the meantime the Simon Commission had been busy with its own work and on October 16th, 1929, after some sort of prearrangement, Sir John Simon wrote to the Prime Minister, Mr. Ramsay Macdonald, asking for an extension of the terms of reference in order to enable him to examine the methods whereby the future relations between the Indian States and the British Indian provinces could be readjusted. He also suggested that after the publication of the Commission's Report, a conference should be arranged between the representatives of His Majesty's Government and representatives of British India and the States. To both these suggestions the Cabinet agreed. The same month Lord Irwin returned to India and soon after his arrival, he issued a statement on October 31st, 1929, saying that he had been 'authorised by His Majesty's Government to state clearly that in their judgment, it is implicit in the Declaration of 1917 that the natural issue of India's constitutional progress, as there contemplated, is the attainment of Dominion Status'. He further stated that a Round Table Conference would be held in London after the publication of the report of the Simon Commission as had been suggested by Sir John Simon himself.

The situation created by this new attitude on the part of the British Cabinet and the Viceroy did not remain unnoticed or unutilised. In the absence of Deshabandhu Das, there was at least one personality who could seize the opportunity at once and, fortunately for him, he then occupied a strategic position as an intermediary between the Viceroy and the people's representatives. That man was Mr. Vithalbhai Patel who, though a veteran Congressman, had been elected to the Presidential chair of the Assembly in 1925. President Patel had had a remarkable public career. An advocate by profession, he had made politics his first love. Through thick and thin, he had been with the Congress for a